Lesson 30

Trouble/Hardship

"In this world you will have trouble."
(John 16:33)

Trouble: a state of distress, affliction, difficulty, or need

We live in a world that is full of troubles. It seems that everywhere we turn, there are problems and difficulties that cause us unrest. Widespread poverty, natural disasters, and hardships of many kinds are common in our modern society. However, in many ways, our current situation is no different than it was when Jesus walked this earth. If you are in trouble, turn to the Bible for help and guidance.

Synopsis

God does not promise a trouble free world; in fact we should expect to have problems and hardships during our time on this earth.[1] Sometimes our troubles are a direct result of our own actions and our own sin.[2] However, this is not always the case. The Bible reminds us that even righteous men experience troubles and hardships,[3] and that we all will have days filled with light and sun, and days filled with darkness.[4]

In this world you will have trouble.
(John 16:33)[1]

There will be trouble and distress
for every human being who does evil.
(Romans 2:9)[2]

A righteous man may have many troubles,
but the LORD delivers him from them all.
(Psalm 34:19)[3]

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Some people are forced to live in poverty. Although the poor and needy may feel that the Lord has forgotten them—He has not.[5] He will take pity on the weak and needy,[6] and He will be their refuge.[7] As Christians, we are to defend the rights of the poor and needy,[8] and speak up for those who are destitute and who cannot speak for themselves.[9]

Other people experience natural disasters and lose most or all of their material possessions. Even in this situation, God does not want us to fear.[10,11] If we call on Him, He will answer us in our distress.[12] We can take refuge in Him.[13]

Light is sweet, and it pleases the eyes to see the sun. However many years a man may live, let him enjoy them all. But let him remember the days of darkness, for they will be many.
(Ecclesiastes 11:7-8)[4]

The needy will not always be forgotten,
nor the hope of the afflicted ever perish.
(Psalm 9:18)[5]

He will take pity on the weak and the needy
and save the needy from death.
(Psalm 72:13)[6]

You have been a refuge for the poor, a refuge for the needy in his distress, a shelter from the storm and a shade from the heat.
(Isaiah 25:4)[7]

Defend the rights of the poor and needy.
(Proverbs 31:9)[8]

Speak up for those who cannot speak for themselves,
for the rights of all who are destitute.
(Proverbs 31:8)[9]

Have no fear of sudden disaster or of the ruin that overtakes the wicked, for the LORD will be your confidence and will keep your foot from being snared.
(Proverbs 3:25)[10]

In God I trust; I will not be afraid. What can man do to me?
(Psalm 56:11)[11]

I call on the LORD in my distress, and he answers me.
(Psalm 120:1)[12]

As human beings, there is a tendency think of all troubles as being "bad." However, God's word reveals that this is not always the case. Sometimes troubles and hardships can serve as "tests of our faith," and can result in glory and honor to God, as Jesus Christ is revealed in us.[14] At other times, hardships are a form of discipline that God allows us to experience because He loves us.[15]

Regardless of the source of our troubles, Christians who are following God's will are urged to look at all problems and hardships from a "positive" perspective. That is, God urges us to be joyful and thankful in all circumstances, regardless of what happens to us.[16]

God's Guidance

The most important thing you can do when you are in trouble is to pray.[17] Take time to pour out your heart to God and tell him all of

I will take refuge in the shadow of your wings
until the disaster has passed.
(Psalm 57:1)[13]

In this you greatly rejoice, though now for a little while you may have had to suffer grief in all kinds of trials. These have come so that your faith—of greater worth than gold, which perishes even though refined by fire—may be proved genuine and may result in praise, glory and honor when Jesus Christ is revealed.
(1 Peter 1:6-7)[14]

Endure hardship as discipline; God is treating you as sons. For what son is not disciplined by his father?
(Hebrews 12:7)[15]

Be joyful always; pray continually; give thanks in all circumstances, for this is God's will for you in Christ Jesus.
(1 Thessalonians 5:16-18)[16]

Is any one of you in trouble? He should pray.
(James 5:13)[17]

your troubles.[18] When we do this, God is always there to help.[19] He will provide refuge, strength,[20] and comfort.[21,22]

If you are in trouble, don't be afraid.[23] Your problems are not too big for the creator of the universe. God has overcome all of the world's problems and troubles.[24]

Finally, instead of focusing exclusively on your own troubles, try reaching out to others. Tell them about God and the comfort they can receive if they turn to Him.[25]

I pour out my complaint before him;
before him I tell my trouble.
(Psalm 142:2)[18]

Then you will call, and the LORD will answer;
you will cry for help, and he will say: Here am I.
(Isaiah 58:9)[19]

God is our refuge and strength,
an ever-present help in trouble.
(Psalm 46:1)[20]

For the LORD comforts his people and will have compassion
on his afflicted ones.
(Isaiah 49:13)[21]

Praise be to the God and Father of our Lord Jesus Christ,
the Father of compassion and the God of all comfort.
(2 Corinthians 1:3)[22]

Do not let your hearts be troubled and do not be afraid.
(James 14:27)[23]

In this world you will have trouble. But take heart!
I have overcome the world.
(John 16:33)[24]

Who comforts us in all our troubles, so that we can comfort
those in any trouble with the comfort we ourselves
have received from God.
(2 Corinthians 1:4)[25]